Using Data to Inform Responsive Professional Learning

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Abstract

In this purposive case study we share the work of embedded professional learning practices in an elementary school that was a member of a school-university collaborative early literacy partnership in six urban schools. First, data were collected to measure classroom instructional practices in literacy through a research-based, faculty designed measure called the Literacy Environment and Instructional Survey (LEIS). Partnered with a rubric that detailed and numbered components of a rich classroom literacy environment and effective literacy instruction, the LEIS was administered in every classroom to capture instructional reading practices. After analyzing grade level data trends, literacy coaches in the partnership, alongside school leaders, organized professional learning communities that addressed specific instructional needs at the school site. This case study illustrates how literacy coaches used data to facilitate professional learning. Over the course of three professional learning community meetings, literacy coaches and K-4 teachers explored literacy practices, learned relevant strategies, and collaborated to plan lessons. Subsequent and ongoing approaches to professional learning included classroom walkthroughs, individual coaching, and reflection. Data collection after professional learning communities and support revealed positive changes in teachers' instructional practices.

Introduction

- Research indicates that students benefit significantly from the instruction of expert reading teachers (e.g., Swartz, 2005; Wharten-McDonald et al., 1998), and the practice of literacy coaching helps ensure that reading teachers become expert instructors who are able to teach students the literacy skills they need to learn (Elish-Piper & L'Allier, 2010).
- The expertise of teachers is strongly connected to general student achievement (e.g., Darling-Hammond, 1999; Joyce & Showers, 2002), and in particular, student achievement in reading (Elish-Piper & L'Allier, 2010; McCutcheon et al., 2002; Swartz, 2005; Wharton-McDonald, Pressley, & Hampston, 1998).
- Effective professional development (PD) is critical for the development of teacher expertise and is characterized by intensive, sustained focus on specific content-related pedagogy, and developing strong working relationships among teachers (Darling-Hammond, Chung Wei, Andree, Richardson, & Orphanos, 2009).

Table 1
Low scoring trends that identify learning objective in professional learning communities

Element of Quality Core Instruction	*Fall*	*Spring*	*Change*
Provides summary	0.9	1.3	+0.4
Provides feedback on student performance	1.4	2.1	+0.7
Asks questions for evaluation	1.4	1.9	+0.5
Assesses student work during the lesson	0.9	1.9	+1.0
Differentiates based on student's levels	0.6	1.0	+0.4
Fosters discussion	1.2	1.0	-0.2
Gives students an opportunity to ask questions	0.5	1.1	+0.6

Method

Measures. To measure quality core instruction as part of the multi-pronged approach to improving reading instruction, several data sources are used including a classroom environmental survey and observation of instruction (collected in the fall and spring of each school year), as well as descriptive data from a minimum of three coaching-cycle interactions conducted in fall, winter, and spring each year between the literacy coach and each participating teacher.

Setting and Participants: This case is part of a larger study in which literacy coaches, faculty members, a non-profit organization, and school staff from a large urban school district and a charter school network work collaboratively to support student reading growth for students in grades K-3. The six schools' student and teacher population represent great diversity in ethnicity, language, and culture. All of the schools were looking for solutions as to why their students were not meeting grade-level benchmarks, and had applied to be a part of the partnership initiative.

Procedures. In a job-embedded professional learning structure, literacy coaches work through student assessment data and teacher observation data to collaboratively plan and reflect on literacy instruction. This case study involves two literacy coaches alongside school leaders who use instructional data to plan learning opportunities in the setting of a professional learning community over the course of three months.

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Results

- A wide variety of embedded coaching procedures have been implemented including observing and providing specific feedback to teachers, coach-modeled small and whole-group lessons, co-teaching, co-planning, consulting, organizing instructional groups, and facilitating whole-class interventions.
- Improvement in quality indicators of evidence-based practices
- Systematic approaches to improving instructional practices in literacy

Figure 1
Using instructional data, literacy coaches used this structure to plan professional learning opportunities for teachers



Limitations

Ecological complexities make connecting achievement to changes in teaching or the classroom environment difficult. Generalizing results from this case study may be problematic because of wide variations in classroom environments and instructional practices.

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